Comfort is Required

Ethics of Pain Management for MOLST Option B/DNR Patients

	Ethical Principle	Application to Option B Pain Management
	**Autonomy**	The patient (or decision-maker) chose a comfort-focused approach. Providing effective analgesia honors that choice.
	**Beneficence**	The primary duty is to relieve suffering. Uncontrolled pain fails this obligation.
	**Non-maleficence**	Withholding needed pain relief causes harm. So does giving interventions the patient has declined.
	**Double Effect**	Analgesics may secondarily hasten death. This is ethically and legally acceptable when the intent is relief of suffering and dosing is proportionate.
	**Dignity**	Comfort supports dignity and quality of remaining life. Pain undermines both.

Key Legal Anchors

Maryland Health-General § 5-608 states that DNR/MOLST orders may not be used to withhold interventions necessary for comfort care or pain relief.

Criminal Law § 3-103 protects providers who give medication to relieve pain even if it may hasten death, as long as the intent is not to cause death.

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